

point. If you want to begin programming quickly, you can use VS Code to start. Then you can consider other editors, once you've gained some experience as a programmer. In this chapter, I'll walk you through installing VS Code on your operating system.

NOTE

If you already have a text editor installed and you know how to configure it to run Python programs, you are welcome to use that editor instead.

Python on Different Operating Systems

Python is a cross-platform programming language, which means it runs on all the major operating systems. Any Python program you write should run on any modern computer that has Python installed. However, the methods for setting up Python on different operating systems vary slightly.

In this section, you'll learn how to set up Python on your system. You'll first check whether a recent version of Python is installed on your system, and install it if it's not. Then you'll install VS Code. These are the only two steps that are different for each operating system.

In the sections that follow, you'll run *hello_world.py* and troubleshoot anything that doesn't work. I'll walk you through this process for each operating system, so you'll have a Python programming environment that you can rely on.

Python on Windows

Windows doesn't usually come with Python, so you'll probably need to install it and then install VS Code.

Installing Python

First, check whether Python is installed on your system. Open a command window by entering **command** into the Start menu and clicking the **Command Prompt** app. In the terminal window, enter **python** in lowercase. If you get a Python prompt (**>>>**) in response, Python is installed on your system. If you see an error message telling you that **python** is not a recognized command, or if the Microsoft store opens, Python isn't installed. Close the Microsoft store if it opens; it's better to download an official installer than to use Microsoft's version.

If Python is not installed on your system, or if you see a version earlier than Python 3.9, you need to download a Python installer for Windows. Go to <https://python.org> and hover over the **Downloads** link. You should see a button for downloading the latest version of Python. Click the button, which should automatically start downloading the correct installer for your system. After you've downloaded the file, run the installer. Make sure you select the option **Add Python to PATH**, which will make it easier to configure your system correctly. Figure 1-1 shows this option selected.